

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE IN GENDER-BASED VIOLENCE IN EMERGENCY PROGRAMMING: PERILS AND POTENTIALS

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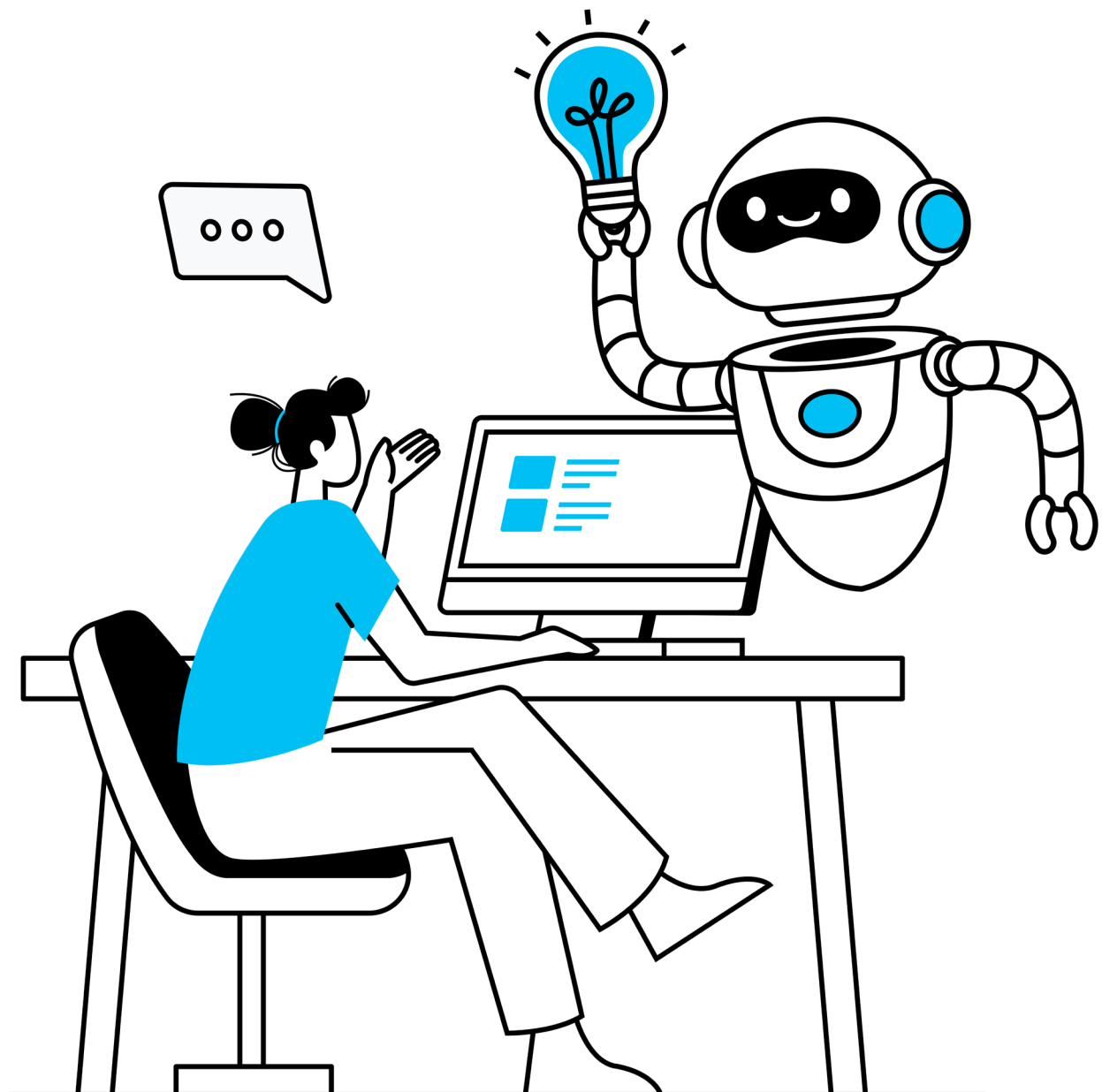


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SUMMARY

The enthusiasm around AI and its potential to revolutionize humanitarian action, including [gender-based violence in emergencies](#) (GBViE) programming, is inescapable. Humanitarian actors are experimenting with and designing pilot projects to test a wide range of AI-powered tools, including chatbots, content generators, language translation and grammar tools, autonomous vehicles, predictive systems, and computer vision.

Integrating AI into GBViE programs brings with it a range of opportunities and risks which vary significantly and are influenced by several factors¹. These include, but are not limited to:

- **The maturity and reliability of the model.** Models that are newer or have had less training as well as models that have poorer performance can create higher risks.
- **The quality of the data.** The quality of both training and live data is crucial to an AI model's performance as bias in data can lead to unfair or inaccurate outcomes for individuals and their communities.
- **The contexts and environments into which models are deployed.** The risks differ depending on where and how the AI is used. This includes the sector or industry in which AI is used, such as healthcare or education, as well as the laws and regulations in place to govern the use of AI in a specific country or context.
- **The frequency with which both the AI model and the related project are reviewed and tested.** Regular reviews and testing are key to ensuring a model and its outputs remain accurate and relevant. Involving third-party assessors is particularly valuable, as they can provide unbiased evaluations of a model's performance and reliability.

This paper provides an overview of these opportunities and risks and suggests ways in which AI—including but not limited to [generative AI](#) and [large language models \(LLMs\)](#) – might be safely and ethically integrated into existing or future programs whilst remaining grounded in core humanitarian commitments and the [GBV Guiding Principles](#), including do no harm, informed consent, and [survivor-centered approaches](#). This includes adopting [feminist approaches to responsible AI](#) and [AI governance](#).

¹ This paper includes various technical terms related to artificial intelligence. For a detailed glossary of these terms, please refer to page 43 : https://odihp.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/11/HPN-Network-Paper_AI_web_181121.pdf

OPPORTUNITIES	RISKS
• AI tools could be used to support social work and case management services. • AI models could offer additional assessments of individual levels of risk to complement human-based risks assessment. • AI tools can offer specialist information to service providers and program staff. • AI could help improve access to remote support and information related to GBViE. • AI can support medical diagnostics. • AI-driven translation, speech, and language tools could help overcome some language barriers. • AI can deliver back-office efficiencies and reduce administrative tasks. • Predictive AI systems can support demand forecasting and supply chain management. • AI can support data analysis. • AI models have proven particularly useful in generating highly localized, actionable maps.	• AI models can generate inaccurate and potentially harmful outputs for a variety of reasons. • AI models can threaten data protection and privacy. • The deployment of AI systems might increase the cognitive overload for case workers and carers. • AI models could be deployed without community input, involvement, or control. • The increased use of AI models could erode the critical human and inter-relational elements of social care. • Integrating AI models into the delivery of GBViE related services could also displace labor, weaken local capacity, and undermine commitments to localize humanitarian action. • AI could erode commitments to existing humanitarian principles, ethics, and GBV core standards. • Gender-biased or anti-feminist AI could be deployed, causing individual and/or societal harms.

Recommendations:**1**

Co-create and co-design AI solutions with women and girls and ensure accountability mechanisms and approaches are designed into the solutions.

2

Agree minimum standards for the use of AI in GBViE programs and establish a process for consulting with women and girls through the design and delivery of AI pilot projects that directly impact their well-being².

3

Build and implement a risk-benefit analysis approach to assess the range of opportunities and trade-offs related to an AI-powered project.

4

Drawing on existing organizational policies and agreed approaches, establish a list of dos and don'ts that sets out limits and options for AI pilot projects designed to support GBViE programs.

5

Establish a technological assurance process that stress tests and ensures the reliability of deployed AI models.

6

Ensure accountability mechanisms and approaches are designed into all AI-enabled programs.

² Currently, there are several efforts underway to define minimum standards on the use of AI in humanitarian response more widely.

7

Explore partnerships with small- and medium-sized, women-led, and female-majority technology firms based in thriving tech hubs across the Global South.

8

Deepen and formalize engagement with leaders in the Feminist AI movement.



INTRODUCTION

The [age of AI](#), by some accounts, has begun, though it remains unclear if current levels of enthusiasm for AI will continue³. AI is having a discernible impact in almost every country and in almost every industry, including the [humanitarian sector](#). AI models have been used to support GBV programs in humanitarian and development contexts alike and have been integrated into related industries, such as healthcare, social work, mental health and psychosocial support (MHPSS), and legal services. This includes but is not limited to: supporting [social services and social work](#) to free up caseworker time; predicting an individual's [risk of future harm](#), including [femicide](#); enhancing [medical diagnostics and testing](#) in low-resource settings; and, leveraging real-time [translation services](#) to deepen engagement between clients, communities, and service providers⁴.

However, not every AI pilot project or application demonstrates value for money and some humanitarians have [raised concerns](#) about the potential harms and risks that AI-enabled interventions pose to women and girls as well as to the core commitments and principles related to [humanitarian action](#) and [GBViE](#), including do no harm, informed consent, accountability, and [localization](#). The inclusion of voices and views of feminists, GBV actors, and women and girls themselves is therefore all the more critical if we are to effectively mitigate the risks associated with AI. Indeed, [feminist approaches](#) to designing and deploying AI can help shift power to and recenter attention on women and girls given [feminist AI's](#) explicit focus on examining and challenging power and hierarchies and making labor visible.

This paper offers suggestions on the specific opportunities and risks related to the use of AI models—including but not limited to predictive systems and generative AI—as well as measures that might enable the safe and responsible uptake of various forms of AI in support of GBViE programs. In addition, this paper seeks to bring the wider GBViE community closer to consensus when considering some of the following questions:

³ There is no one, universally accepted definition of AI. Broadly speaking, AI is the science and technology of creating intelligent systems or machine-based systems that simulate human comprehension and problem-solving or performs tasks that [ordinarily require human brainpower](#) to achieve. This includes generative AI or genAI, AI models that create text, images, video, and other content. While this paper does not provide an overview of key concepts and terminology related to AI, additional material along these lines can be found at: the [BBC](#), [Carnegie Mellon University](#), the [HPN](#), the [JSO](#), [MIT Sloane](#), and [The Alan Turing Institute](#).

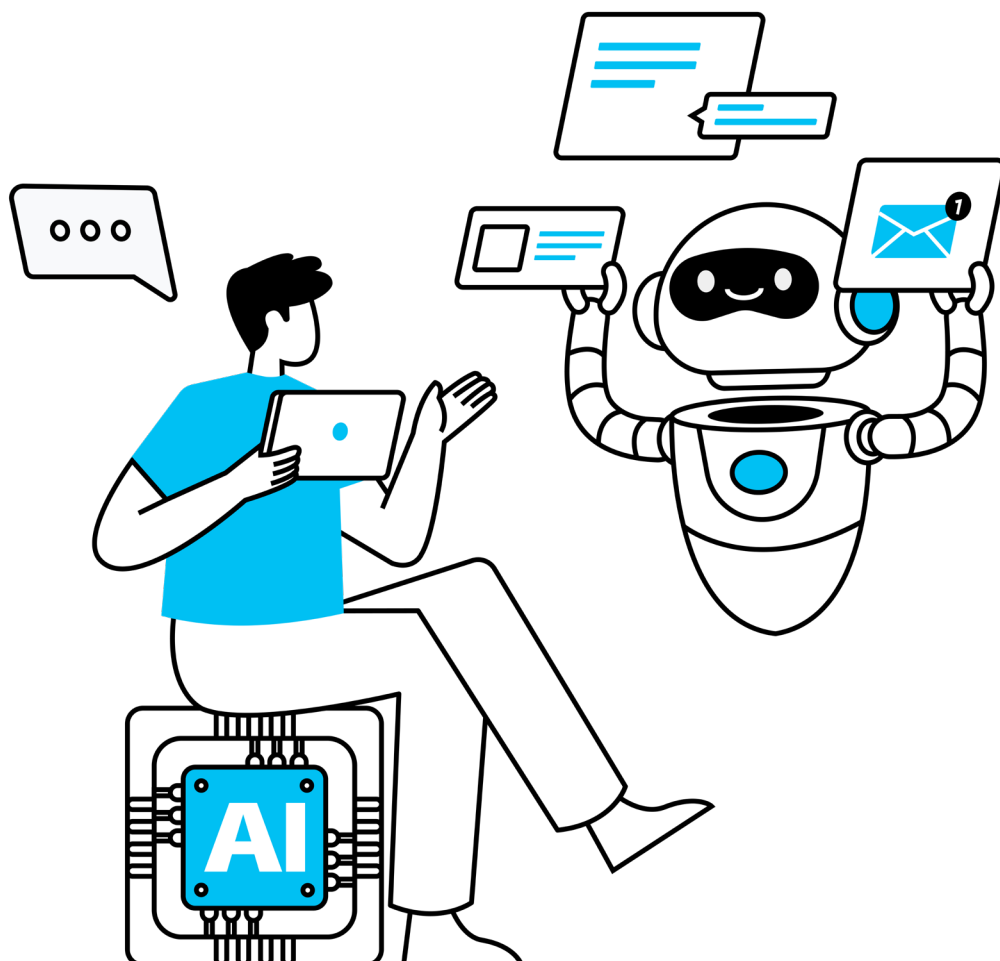
⁴ While some of these use cases involve the use of chatbots and virtual assistants, generative AI tools do not represent the entirety of AI's current capability and future potential.

Can AI models be safely deployed to address GBViE or does it pose too many risks?

How can AI systems be used to support GBV survivors and what are the potential pitfalls and critical ethical challenges that need to be addressed?

How can AI be safely and responsibly integrated into GBV programs in a way that is survivor-centered and grounded in core commitments and principles?

How can GBV actors collaborate with key stakeholders, including tech companies, local women's organizations, and academia to leverage their expertise and resources in implementing ethical and responsible AI solutions for GBV prevention and response?



POTENTIAL OPPORTUNITIES FOR AI, AND GBViE PROGRAMMING

This section suggests several ways in which AI might be used to support GBViE programming though this list is not exhaustive. It is critical to note that the interventions listed below are at different stages of development and some pose much higher risks to communities and GBViE clients than others. Additionally, evidence on the impact of these interventions, where it exists, is mixed. The risks related to these interventions are discussed in further detail in section 4.

AI-powered tasks to improve efficiency of social work and case management services.

AI tools could be used to support [social work](#) and case management services, potentially [freeing up social worker time](#) by automating administrative tasks, reducing paperwork, and minimizing time spent on other monotonous activities, such as data entry related to Primero/GBVIMS+. AI-powered [scheduling tools](#) and [voice-to-text applications](#) can be particularly useful, especially as the accuracy of the latter has significantly improved, though they also increase risks to data protection and privacy (see below). AI systems can also assist in tracking case progress and outcomes, flagging when appointments are missed, assisting with triage and referrals, or providing other insights into a case. In cases where AI tools demonstrably free up caseworkers' time and where risks to privacy and data protection are effectively mitigated (see below), this could increase the amount of face-to-face time clients have with a caseworker and deliver deeper impact for them.

AI-powered individual risk assessment. AI models could offer assessments of individual levels of risk to complement human-based risks assessment by identifying and analyzing patterns in vast amounts of data, including risk factors associated with violence. While this solution remains largely untested, some argue that AI systems can help predict [risks of harm](#), helping social workers and other carers [prioritize cases that require immediate action](#) and increase the time they allocate to individual clients. This application could be particularly helpful in detecting and preventing risks of lethal acts of violence and supporting [suicide prevention](#) efforts. However, [evidence from high income countries suggests](#) that even in cases where the accuracy of model is high, using these predictions in high-stakes decisions related to social work can create other ethical challenges. For example, by drawing on existing data sets from social care and criminal justice systems, models have been found to amplify historic bias and discrimination and reinforce structural inequalities. And, using AI models to assess individual risk can also undermine the

relationship between a case worker and client or even dehumanize clients by shifting a carer's focus away from the core principles and commitments related to GBV response—such as client empowerment and agency, empathy, and trust—and towards data and data-driven decision-making. These risks are particularly acute where feminist approaches to AI are not included in the design of an AI model and AI-related projects.

AI-powered technical guidance for GBV practitioners. AI tools, particularly LLMs, can offer specialist information to service providers and program staff based on best practice and minimum standards related to GBViE, existing legislation and case law, or GBV-related services available in a specific location. This includes [guidelines on case management](#) and the [clinical management of rape](#). Given the risks related to algorithmic error (see below), AI-generated outputs should always be quality assured by a human expert, particularly where they inform decisions about individual well-being or other high-stakes decisions. Additionally, cognitive biases—including [anchoring bias](#) and [confirmation bias](#)—have [been shown to impact](#) how a person processes, assesses, and acts upon the information provided by AI models. Some individuals, for example, might see AI outputs as superior to that of human experts which might make it less likely for them to spot AI errors or failures, undermining the quality of the care offered. Where individuals are less trusting of AI systems and their outputs, this might increase the amount of time spent on decisions that draw on both human and AI outputs, particularly in cases where human experts disagree with AI outputs. (See also information on cognitive overload, below.)

AI powered chatbots or virtual assistance for GBV 1:1 support. AI could help improve access to remote support and information through chatbots and other virtual assistants, helping women and girls [access information 24/7](#), in confidential and anonymized settings, about their rights and GBV-related services. They can also provide some very basic elements of psychological first aid (PFA) although this application is very high-risk and evidence on the impact of this support, where it exists, is [mixed](#) and often specific to high-income countries. Virtual assistants can also be used to seek and analyze feedback from clients on the quality of GBV-related services and other care. However, given their potential for algorithmic error and failure—including hallucinations⁵ and inaccurate or biased outputs—the risks related to virtual assistants must be clearly identified and mitigated before deploying them in high-risk settings.

⁵ Hallucinations are inaccurate, misleading, or nonsensical outputs generated by an AI model or, put more simply, when a model invents facts that sound plausible but are imaginary. Read more in these articles from MIT Sloan and University of Oxford.

AI-powered medical diagnostics. AI models, including those with computer vision capabilities, have been integrated into medical diagnostic services to improve the accuracy of testing in low-resources settings. This includes screening for [cervical cancer](#), [tuberculosis](#), and [anti-microbial resistance](#), the latter of which could prove useful in the [clinical management of rape](#) by improving the effectiveness of antibiotic prescriptions. Some early trials have also included [feminist AI](#) efforts to upskill locally employed workers and keep a “[human-in-the-loop](#)” in both the design of AI systems and their deployment to reduce the potential impact of any algorithmic errors and lower the chances of local labor displacement in favor of high-tech solutions.

Translation and speech synthesis software. AI-driven translation, speech, and language tools could help overcome some language barriers, supporting community consultations and community-level assessments—including GBViE needs assessments, safety audits, and evaluations—and making GBV-related services more inclusive and representative, in-line with [feminist approaches to AI](#). This could improve accountability to clients and communities in crisis, improve the quality of the services and support on offer, and make GBV-related services more accessible for non-native speakers and those with communication difficulties. These benefits could increase as the speed of real-time translation increases and as translation tools add more languages to their systems⁶. However, many digital translation tools remain unable to translate low-resource and non-dominant languages and/or key concepts related to GBViE and most of the highest performing LLM [serve under a dozen](#) languages⁷.

Use of AI for project management and administrative tasks. AI can deliver back-office efficiencies and reduce administrative tasks. Generative AI tools are increasingly used by large and small organizations alike to assist with proposal writing, generate communications and marketing materials, including behavior change messaging, and help with donor reports. Some argue that this could [level the playing field](#) between larger NGOs and local organizations, though evidence to this end remains limited. AI models can enhance data analysis—for example, assessment-related data or incident data—by analyzing greater amounts of data more quickly and automating pattern and trend identification beyond the capacity of human analysts, allowing for quicker and more accurate insights. It can also support data visualization, generating clear and insightful graphs and reports, making complex data more accessible and understandable for a broader range of stakeholders. And AI systems are increasingly being used to transform slightly complex content into more user-friendly material to improve the material's accessibility.

⁶ In 2024, Google used its LLM PaLM 2 to add 110 languages to Google Translate, bringing the total number of languages it translates to 247 out of the estimated 7,000 languages spoken across the world. <https://blog.google/products/translate/google-translate-new-languages-2024/>

⁷ See, [Language and Digital Humanitarian Action: The state of inclusion and exclusion for marginalised language speakers in digital humanitarian services](#).

Use of AI for supply chain management and forecasting. Predictive AI systems can support demand forecasting and [supply chain management](#) by analyzing historical data to predict future needs, [reducing waste and other costs](#) related to shipping and storage. This might prove useful for managing supplies of dignity kits and other GBV-related response supplies, for example post-exposure prophylaxis and post-rape kits, ensuring that the right antibiotics and medication are in-stock, optimizing inventory levels, and improving client outcomes.

Use of AI for data analysis. AI can analyze vast amounts of data to identify patterns and trends that may not be immediately evident. Using advanced algorithms, AI can process data from various sources—such as the GBVIMS, public records, and health services—to predict high-risk locations and populations who face higher risks. It can ease the process of triangulating GBV incident or survivor data with contextualized data (e.g. GBV safety audits, prevalence survey, administrative data, etc.) This might allow organizations to design more targeted and effective prevention and response programs. It can further support data interpretation in order to accompany GBV actors to reflect on program adaptation and advocacy. Additionally, AI can help evaluate the impact of these interventions over time, providing valuable insights for continuous improvement.

Use of AI for generating heat maps. AI models have proven particularly useful in generating [highly localized, actionable maps](#)—merging multiple data sets, including direct and proxy measures of need as well as satellite imagery—which can support needs assessments and program design. This includes maps that assess building and infrastructure damage as well as localized, sex-disaggregated maps of [community practices and beliefs](#) which offer a potential complementary source of information for agencies conducting GBV assessments.

POTENTIAL RISKS RELATED TO AI, AND GBViE PROGRAMMING

The following section offers a list of potential risks related to AI, GBViE, and GBViE programming. It is important to note that these risks are by no means guaranteed and the language used to describe the risks should not be interpreted as indicating any specific likelihood or probability of them happening. Additionally, this list of risks is not exhaustive and continuous monitoring of AI projects is required to identify new risks as they arise.

Many of the risks associated with AI deployment in humanitarian emergencies fall into one or more of the following 3 categories: (1) risks related to intentional harms and violence perpetrated using AI-supported tools; (2) risks related to a model's performance; and (3) risks related to the design and delivery of an AI-related project. This includes the extent to which the outputs or information generated by an AI model are used to inform important decisions that affect people's well-being, the specific context where the AI solution is being used, and whether women, girls, and/or their communities have agreed to the use of AI and the design of the AI-related project.

While this paper focuses only on the latter two (see below), it is important to note that AI tools can directly increase the severity, frequency, or likelihood of violence to women and girls perpetrated by governments and state actors, parties to conflict, intimate partners, and others (see box, "AI-enabled violence against women and girls").

Box. AI-enabled violence against women and girls. As the accuracy and performance of AI improves and its accessibility increases, so too do the risks AI poses to violence against women and girls. AI tools can be used to [surveil](#) and [stalk](#) women and girls, tracking their movements, monitoring their communications, and [collecting personal information](#). AI tools also [make it easier](#) to create [non-consensual intimate images \(NCII\)](#), also known as [deepfake pornography](#), which can be used to publicly humiliate, shame, discredit, threaten, control, and/or financially coerce women and girls, sometimes resulting in physical harm, including suicide. And AI systems can be used by governments and non-state actors as a [weapon of repression](#), monitoring and suppressing feminist movements, [women's organizations](#), and others working for social justice.

AI models can generate inaccurate and potentially harmful outputs for a [variety of reasons](#). This includes algorithmic design failures, safety flaws, bias in the design of the algorithm, and bias in the algorithm's training and/or real-time data, often referred to as [algorithmic biases](#). Biased training data as well as the individual [biases of AI engineers](#) can amplify and entrench systemic discrimination and prejudice, perpetuating existing inequalities and embedding them into automated systems, leading to unfair and discriminatory outcomes for historically marginalized and disenfranchised communities. It also includes model errors or failures linked to attacks by outside actors exploiting vulnerabilities in an algorithm and/or its data, also known as [adversarial attacks](#).

Some inaccuracies can be difficult to spot, such as the steady, marginal decrease in the accuracy of predictive models. If acted upon, inaccurate outputs can generate poor outcomes for women and girls, for example, if AI models offer inaccurate information related to GBV services, perpetuate stereotypes or produce discriminatory outputs, or fail to appropriately account for cultural dynamics characteristics. These risks are higher in cases where community-facing AI applications generate outputs that directly affect the well-being of women and girls.

[Regular assurance](#) testing and monitoring (see below) can help assess algorithmic performance, robustness, and reliability. This includes regularly reviewing the training and live data on which the model runs and ensuring that the model works as it was designed to when it is used in real-world contexts. When problems or errors do occur, accountability policies and mechanisms can help those who are harmed or adversely affected seek redress, particularly mechanisms in-line with global standards on AI accountability. (See "Recommendations".)

AI models can threaten data protection and privacy. Integrating AI models into existing programs increases their digital surface area, providing more entry points for potential hacks and cyberattacks. AI systems rely on complex technological infrastructure and connections to data networks, which, if not properly secured, become vulnerable to hacking. AI can lower the barriers to entry for would-be hackers by automating attacks and exploiting system weaknesses more efficiently. Models that interface with sensitive, personal information—such as voice-to-text tools to document sensitive and/or personal information related to GBV incidents and clients—can also increase the likelihood of data breaches and unauthorized access. Moreover, a growing body of research suggests that AI tools can re-identify most anonymized datasets, posing risks to any efforts to collect and store sensitive or personally identifiable information. Given that many individuals affected by crises and conflicts should have control over the collection and use of their data and the threats that AI poses to individual privacy, this makes informed consent all the more critical and urgent.

The deployment of AI systems might increase the cognitive overload for case workers and careers, requiring them to process too much information or deal with too many complex tasks at the same time. Some experts [have suggested](#) that AI places a higher cognitive burden on humans when it is integrated into high-stakes decision-making processes, particularly in cases where humans are continuously interpreting complex AI outputs, monitoring system performance, and required to make rapid, critical judgments. This heightened cognitive demand can lead to stress, reduced decision quality, and potential errors, particularly in high-pressure environments. Other studies suggest that some individuals spend more time scrutinizing algorithmic outputs than they would human outputs, thus increasing the amount of time spent on a task or specific problem. This can [ultimately slow the pace of work](#) rather than improving individual productivity, though evidence to this end in the field of social work and social services remains limited.

AI models could be deployed without community input, involvement, or control, undermining commitments to community participation and accountability and potentially resulting in services which fail to account for community needs. The extent to which humanitarian actors have engaged with and consulted women and girls and others impacted by algorithmic decision-making remains unclear. This not only includes consultations on how AI will impact them but also: whether women and girls have been involved in the design of an AI solution; whether they are aware that AI systems are being used to inform decisions that affect them; the extent to which their consent has been sought and received on the use of AI in decisions that impact their well-being; and how their personal data interacts with these models.

Moreover, as the accuracy of AI models increases, so too does the risk that community consultations and participation is deemed less relevant. For example, if more accurate AI outputs enable more accurate anticipatory humanitarian action or a quicker and more geographically precise response, some actors might see less value in seeking input from crisis-affected communities. Additionally, some have argued that key concepts related to AI and how it works are too complicated to explain to rural communities with low rates of digital literacy or connectivity, but [early consultation efforts](#) and research on [AI governance](#) and [trust](#) suggest that in some low-resource contexts, communities are aware of AI and have views on its use. Community engagement could also be strengthened by grounding consultations about AI in more universal concepts. This includes the use of non-technological tools and proxy measures to predict future events, for example the way in which some communities use environmental and meteorological indicators to predict future agricultural output or seasonal climate changes.

The increased use of AI models could [erode the critical human and inter-relational elements](#) of social care. In instances where individuals consciously or unconsciously favor AI outputs over those of human experts, this could devalue human, specialist expertise, particularly where AI models are used to provide technical information typically offered by supervisors or GBViE technical advisors. Additionally, in cases where organizations deploy chatbots to provide direct MHPSS to clients⁸, this could reduce the total number of community volunteers, community-based staff, or locally engaged employees delivering MHPSS and PFA and have knock-on negative impacts on community cohesion, household income, and localization (see below), notwithstanding the risks associated with algorithmic error and inaccurate AI outputs discussed above, and how these might [impact the quality of MHPSS](#) provided.

Integrating AI models into the delivery of GBViE related services could also displace labor, weaken local capacity, and undermine commitments to [localize humanitarian action](#). While applications of AI have improved efficiency in some industries, doing the same for humanitarian and GBViE programs could reduce [frontline jobs](#), such as GBV program managers and other administrators, potentially [undermining the sector's collective agreement](#) to shift power and resources to the [Global South](#). Furthermore, many humanitarians have established partnerships with AI firms in the Global North, some of whom have mixed track records when it comes to [race](#), [gender](#), power, and social justice. Some of these efforts to localize AI efforts in the Global South are oftentimes more cosmetic than intentional. For example, some AI firms have [outsourced the labelling of training data](#) to low-paid contractors in the Global South who were tasked with identifying data that was racist, violent, and/or abusive yet often had little or [no access to mental health support](#), even after reviewing and labelling untold hours of extremely violent data. Partnerships with these firms also risks shifting power and attention (largely) away from the Global South while ignoring the potential of tech firms based in-country or in the wider region. [UNICEF's Venture Fund](#) has helped surface indigenous firms in program countries with whom humanitarian actors might partner (see below).

AI could erode commitments to existing humanitarian principles, ethics, and GBV core standards. This includes accountability to affected populations and support for survivor-centered approaches. As noted above, introducing AI and other technological tools can shift attention away from women and girls, GBViE clients, and human-centered approaches if the proper guidelines and governance procedures are not in place. It can also undermine informed consent in cases where program-related or other sensitive data is used to train or help run AI models. And some researchers have warned that the

⁸ At the time of writing, multiple organizations are exploring the possibility of deploying chatbots to provide some rudimentary forms of MHPSS in forced displacement contexts.

increased use of AI tools in contexts where human empathy is critical—such as MHPSS chatbots that are trained to mimic human beings’ emotional intelligence—could [dehumanize GBViE survivors](#) and the relationship between a carer and a client.

Multiple guidelines and [standards](#) on [responsible AI and AI governance](#) exist and the adoption of these standards should build upon and not replace hard-won sector-specific principles and commitments related to GBViE, including the GBV Guiding Principles. Non-technical [AI standards](#) developed by the [NIST](#), [ISO](#), and other standards development organizations offer guidance on how to improve accountability to those who might be harmed by AI outputs and how to manage the risks related to AI integration. However, little is known about the extent to which humanitarian actors have drawn on these tools to develop sector-specific standards.

Gender-biased or anti-feminist AI could be deployed, causing individual and/or societal harms. In North America, [women account for only one in five students](#) enrolled in AI and computer science PhD programs and account for [22 percent of AI and data science professionals](#) in the UK. Some technology firms have a mixed track record of understanding and engineering AI in pro-feminist ways. For example, some early image generators were [unable to create images of two women](#) kissing as it has been categorized as pornography in the [model’s training data](#) and thus excluded. And a number of renowned researchers and academics have demonstrated how algorithms, particularly facial recognition algorithms, [can perpetuate gender and racial bias](#). There is a well-established [movement that seeks to integrate feminist principles into the development and deployment of AI](#) and advocating for [improved transparency, accountability, and participatory design processes](#) with the aim of creating AI systems that promote gender equity, inclusivity, and advance social justice. However, the extent to which humanitarian actors have connected with the movement remains unclear.

RECOMMENDATIONS

1

Co-create and co-design AI solutions with women and girls and ensure accountability mechanisms and approaches are designed into the solutions, even if nascent or from other contexts. This includes assessing the readiness, maturity, and robustness of the AI solution and datasets as well as the context into which the solution is delivered, including the data/AI regulatory measures in place as well as the political context. As a number of researchers have noted, the risks attributed to AI are as much a consequence of its deployment (proposed use, context, and users) as they are its design (parameters, data, bias).

2

Agree minimum standards for the use of AI in GBViE programs and establish a process for consulting with women and girls through the design and delivery of AI pilot projects that directly impact their well-being. This might be in the form of a standalone toolkit to guide consultations with women and girls to explore their views and recommendations on the use of AI, building on [early efforts to consult with refugees on the use of AI](#) as well as [human-centered design](#) approaches and [feminist AI principles](#) that situate women and girls at the center of technology development. A specific component or standalone section documenting the results of public consultations should be included in all AI/ML model cards when pilot projects are designed⁹. The results of these consultations should not only feed into the design and delivery of specific AI projects but contribute to a wider corpus of information on how communities—particularly women and girls—view AI and how it is could be used to deliver GBViE-related services. In addition, these consultation processes could be extended to include local women’s organizations and providers of GBViE-related services to surface their views on AI and its potential to support (not replace) their work.

⁹ TModel cards are employed to enhance AI transparency by providing detailed documentation on the model’s development, performance, and intended use, thereby fostering greater understanding and accountability across all parties interacting with the model. Many model cards fail to include details on societal harms, public consultations, and accountability to parties directly impacted by model outputs though many experts agree that including this information in a model card supports broader efforts related to AI explainability, transparency, and trust.

3

Build and implement a risk-benefit analysis approach to assess the range of opportunities and trade-offs related to an AI-powered project.

This would not only include measurements of financial cost and staff time but also an estimate of the impact on labor displacement and local employment opportunities, the agency and voice of communities and local women's organizations, community cohesion, and the impact on ethical principles and commitments central to GBViE and humanitarian action, in-line with [feminist approaches to AI](#). This should also include safeguarding and ethical assessments of each project, noting that risks may vary across context and solution.

The analysis should include a detailed assessment of key “winners” and potential “losers”. For example, this might include losses for community volunteers in cases where AI models preclude their work. Any assessment of AI-related risk should be grounded in global standards related to risk management, including the [NIST AI Risk Management Framework](#) and [ISO/IEC 42001:2023](#), and ensure that risk treatment options are ascribed to identified risks and regularly reviewed and updated.

4

Drawing on existing organizational policies and agreed approaches and feminist approaches to AI, establish a list of dos and don'ts that sets out limits and options for AI pilot projects designed to support GBViE programs.

This might include, for example: ensuring AI projects meet GBV minimum standards and humanitarian principles; prioritizing areas where efficiency gains benefit the Global South; precluding projects where AI models are used in support of high-risks decisions, such as medical diagnoses and caregiving decisions for under-18s; prohibiting the interaction between AI models and any personally identifiable information related to under-18s, including biometric data; restricting the scale-up of AI pilot projects in the absence of meaningful community consultations and public disclosure on the use of AI; providing evidence that local tech suppliers have been assessed and/or consulted with.

5

Establish a technological assurance process that stress tests and ensures the reliability of deployed AI models. AI assurance

includes rigorous testing, validation exercises, and auditing processes as well as incident reporting, monitoring, and redress. Third party assurance firms can assess an algorithm's performance against specified criteria, identify potential biases or errors, and verify that an AI operates as intended across various scenarios. Additionally, they make recommendations for improvements to enhance the system's reliability and trustworthiness.

6

Ensure accountability mechanisms and approaches are designed into all AI-enabled programs.

These should draw on existing global standards related to AI accountability and feminist approaches to AI as well as humanitarian commitments related to accountability to affected populations and community participation. They should also include policies that outline redress measures to help those who are harmed or adversely affected by algorithmic outputs. This includes establishing feedback loops between the program teams deploying AI models and the women and girls directly affected by the models' outputs. Feedback received from women and girls should shape project-related decisions and any changes to the design of the project should be shared with communities. Feedback should also improve the design of AI-enabled projects as well as the AI models and the data on which they draw.

7

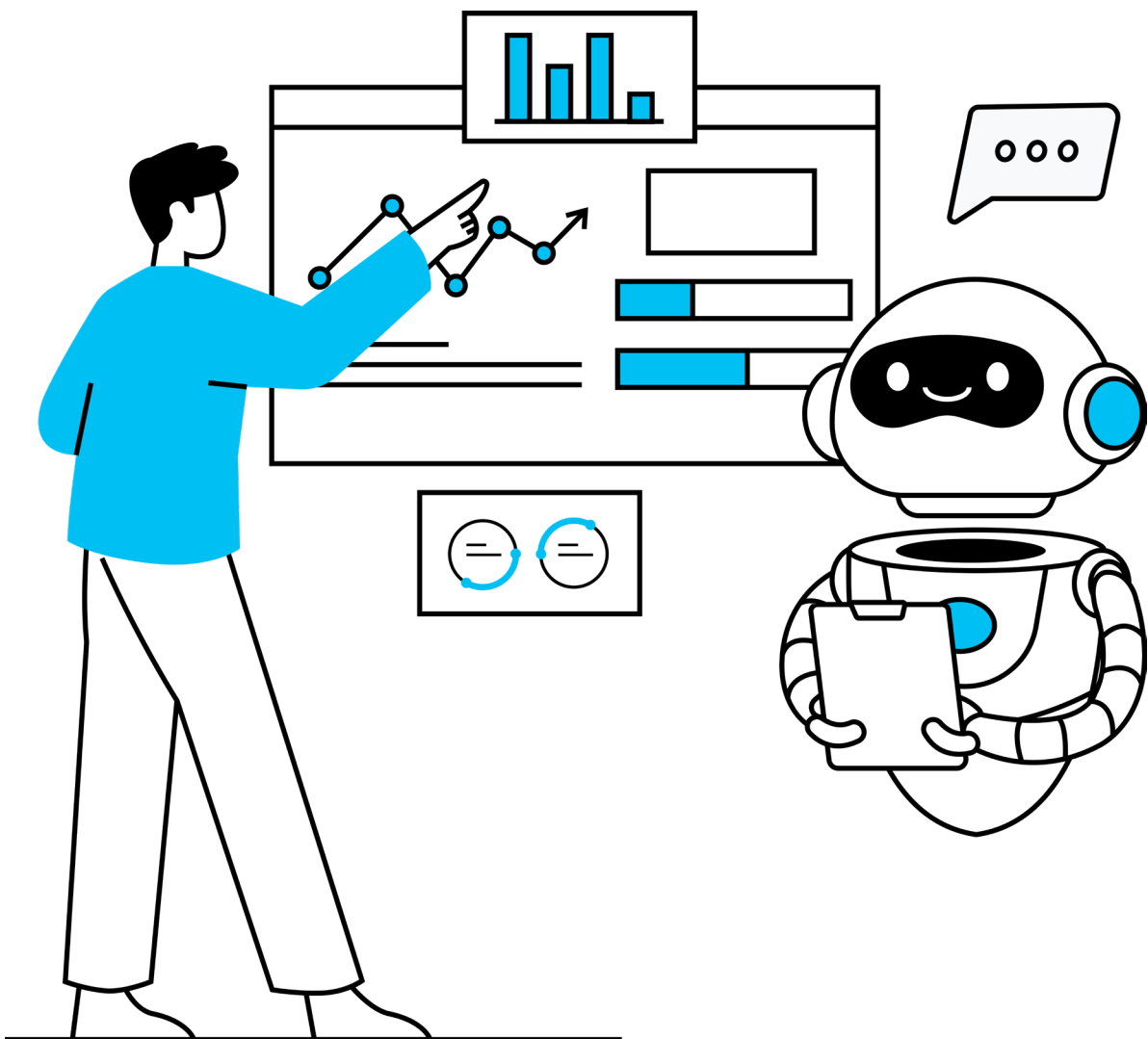
Explore partnerships with small- and medium-sized, women-led, and female-majority technology firms based in thriving tech hubs across the Global South.

While these firms typically have fewer "off the shelf" products—and thus might require more time and resources than big tech firms to develop fit-for-purpose products—a large number have missions and goals explicitly linked with the SDGs. Equally, some offer solutions that are more relevant to the local context, such as chatbots trained in local languages. Early market engagement processes and market assessments in key tech hubs across the Middle East, South Asia, and sub-Saharan Africa—in line with the work of UNICEF's Venture Fund—can help surface such firms, particularly those with feminist values and linked to the FemTech movement.

8

Deepen and formalize engagement with leaders in the Feminist AI movement,

Deepen and formalize engagement with thought leaders and practitioners in the Feminist AI movement to advance responsible, ethical, and inclusive approaches to technology in humanitarian contexts. This could involve establishing an Advisory Group that convenes 2 to 3 times a year, offering strategic guidance on integrating Feminist AI principles into program design and implementation. The Advisory Group would serve as a platform for fostering collaboration, ensuring the alignment of technology-driven interventions with feminist values, and bridging gaps between ethical AI frameworks and practical applications in the field.



ANNEX I. RISKS AND OPPORTUNITIES

POTENTIAL AI OPPORTUNITIES	POTENTIAL BENEFITS	POTENTIAL RISKS	OVERALL RISK ASSESSMENT
1. AI-powered tasks to improve efficiency of social work and case management services.	Frees up caseworker time to spend more time in 1:1 engagement with clients; provides additional insights into cases; flags issues of concern.	Algorithmic errors or failures lead to individual harms, for example if an AI fails to flag high-risk issues of concern; biased data leads to harm, particularly if AI is learning from inaccurate results; client data is hacked or leaked; the principle of informed consent is increasingly overlooked in favor of AI-generated outputs and recommendations; could increase caseworkers' cognitive overload, particularly in cases where AI tools are not user friendly and/or where trust in the tool and its outputs is low.	 Medium risk; proceed with caution. Risks related to data privacy are significant and evidence on the impact of this opportunity is mixed, even in high-resource contexts.
2. AI-powered individual risk assessment.	Predicts risks of harm or recidivism, helping caseworkers prioritize case load; helps predict and prevent potentially lethal acts of violence and suicide.	Algorithmic errors or failures lead to individual harms if the tool incorrectly assess individual-level risks; the principle of informed consent and/or respecting the voice and agency of clients is increasingly overlooked in favor of AI-generated outputs and recommendations; strong risk of bias in the data leading to harm if AI is learning from inaccurate results.	 High risk; proceed with extreme caution. Evidence on the impact of this opportunity is limited, even in high-resource contexts with significant levels of human oversight and verification, and uptake has therefore been low.

POTENTIAL AI OPPORTUNITIES	POTENTIAL BENEFITS	POTENTIAL RISKS	OVERALL RISK ASSESSMENT
3. AI-powered technical guidance for GBV practitioners.	Offers consistent and immediate access to reliable information, complementing that provided by supervisor.	Algorithmic errors or failures lead to individual harms, for example if an AI hallucinates or provides harmful information that is acted upon; displaces local labor or reduces the number of frontline staff; undermines commitments to localization if attention and resources are shifted to AI models and headcount of country-based staff are reduced.	 Medium risk; proceed with caution. Chatbots and virtual assistants can still generate inaccurate information which could directly harm clients and devalue human expertise.
4. AI powered chatbots or virtual assistance for GBV 1:1 support.	Offers access to relevant information 24/7 in confidential and/or anonymized settings.	Algorithmic errors or failure leads to individual harms, for example if an AI hallucinates or provides harmful information that is acted upon; chatbots and other virtual assistants fail to adopt cultural and linguistic idiosyncrasies, particularly as most LLMs are trained in just a few languages; displaces or reduces the need for community volunteers or community-based staff who currently provide such information, with potentially negative impacts on community cohesion and household income; strong risk of bias in the data leading to harm if AI is learning from inaccurate results.	 Medium risk; proceed with caution. As above, chatbots and virtual assistants are still prone to generating inaccurate information which could directly harm women and girls.

POTENTIAL AI OPPORTUNITIES	POTENTIAL BENEFITS	POTENTIAL RISKS	OVERALL RISK ASSESSMENT
5. AI-powered medical diagnostics.	Improves accuracy of testing in low-resource environments, thus improving treatment and reducing morbidity and mortality.	Algorithmic errors or failure leads to individual harms, for example if a human fails to verify outputs of the model or if the model is trained on data that fails to adequately represent the individuals and communities in which it is deployed (gender, ethnicity, language); displaces local labor or reduces the number of frontline staff; undermines commitments to localization if attention and resources are shifted to AI models and headcount of country-based staff are reduced.	 Medium risk; proceed with caution. Ensure appropriate measures are adopted to ensure humans verify AI outputs and that frontline staff adequately trained and included in the delivery of the project.
6. Translation and speech synthesis software.	Increases the accessibility of services for speakers of non-dominant languages; improves assessments and evaluations for GBV programming.	Algorithmic errors or failure leads to individual harms; displaces local labor or reduces the number of frontline staff; undermines commitments to localization if attention and resources are shifted to AI models and headcount of country-based staff are reduced.	 Low risk; proceed slowly, design carefully, and test iteratively. Do not share any personal or protected information with the AI tool. Ensure the outputs are verified by a human.

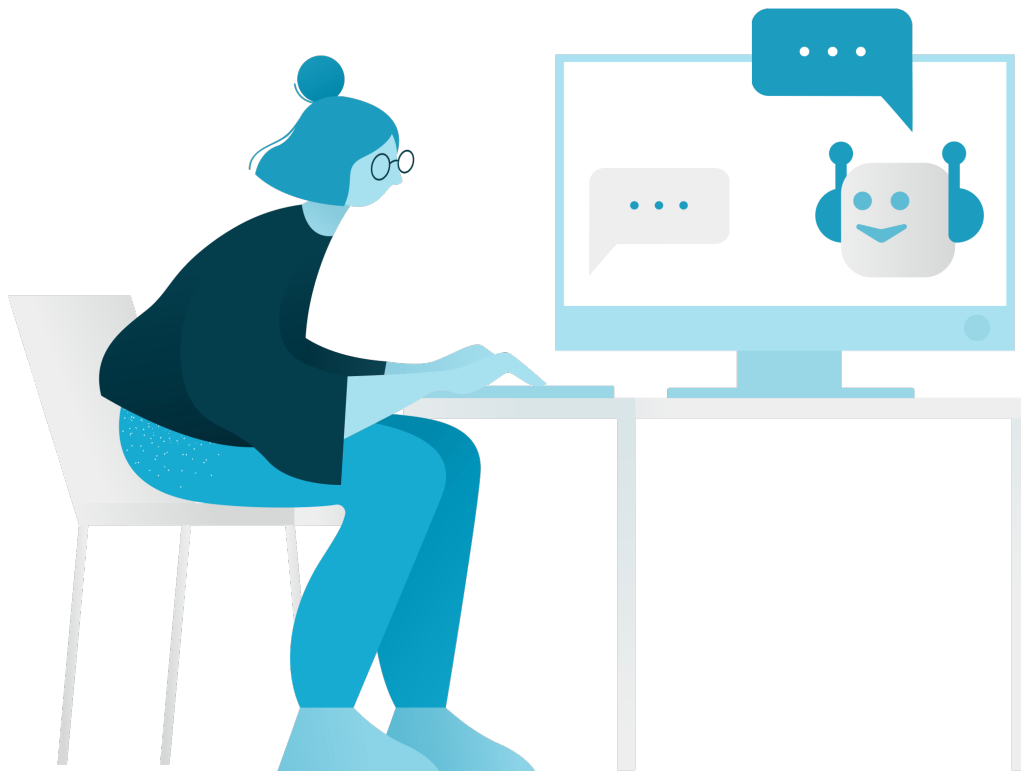
POTENTIAL AI OPPORTUNITIES	POTENTIAL BENEFITS	POTENTIAL RISKS	OVERALL RISK ASSESSMENT
7. Use of AI for project management and administrative tasks.	Improves individual productivity and/or the efficiencies of individuals teams or programs.	Algorithmic errors or failure generates inaccurate outputs that are difficult to discern in some use cases or contexts, for example: displaces local labor or reduces the number of frontline staff; undermines commitments to localization if attention and resources are shifted to AI models and headcount of country-based staff are reduced.	 Low risk; proceed slowly, design carefully, and test iteratively. Do not share any personal or protected information with the AI tool. Ensure the outputs are verified by a human.
8. Use of AI for supply chain management and forecasting	Reduces waste and costs related to shipping and storage; reduces the size and duration of supply shortfalls.	Algorithmic errors or failures leads to errors in supply distribution and waste; increases reliance in algorithmic predictions, reducing commitment to community consultations for needs assessment and information collection.	 Medium risk; proceed with caution. AI errors could disrupt supplies of lifesaving or life-improving materials. Regular AI assurance and stress-testing is critical.

POTENTIAL AI OPPORTUNITIES	POTENTIAL BENEFITS	POTENTIAL RISKS	OVERALL RISK ASSESSMENT
9. Use of AI for data analysis	Can rapidly process and analyze high volumes of data from multiple sources and reveal previously unidentified patterns and insights.	Algorithmic errors or failure in AI solutions related to data analysis and risk predictions can be difficult to spot; strong risk of bias in the data leading to harm if AI is learning from inaccurate results; increases reliance in algorithmic predictions, reducing commitment to community consultations for needs assessment and information collection.	 Medium risk; proceed with caution. Risks related to data privacy are significant and AI errors could lead to poor allocation of limited resources. Regular AI assurance and stress-testing is critical.
10. Use of AI for generating heat maps.	Provides highly localized, actionable maps to improve assessments and program delivery.	Reduces commitment to community consultations for needs assessment and information collection, especially if the outputs of the model are accurate and humanitarian/GBViE actors no longer see less value in community-based assessments.	 Low risk; proceed slowly, design carefully, and test iteratively. Ensure commitments to accountability and community consultation are prioritized.

ANNEX II. SCENARIOS

The following scenarios present examples of AI pilot projects, inspired by real stories. These scenarios are intended to spark debate and discussion between GBViE staff on the extent to which AI could and should be integrated into programs and how to safely and ethically adopt AI solutions in high-risk contexts, like humanitarian crises and emergencies.

Scenario 1. CM-Bot, an AI solution to improve the efficiency of social work / case management services and provide technical guidance for GBV practitioners



In a large, rural refugee camp with good digital connectivity but with limited financial resources for GBViE programs, a local NGO, providing case management services for women and girls, is struggling to keep up with the growing demand for services. The team consists of a handful of caseworkers and 1 Program Manager.

To reduce the administrative burden on caseworkers, the Program Manager and Director decide to integrate a Large Language Model (LLM) chatbot into their workflow called CM-Bot. Access to CM-Bot has been donated by a European software firm to the local

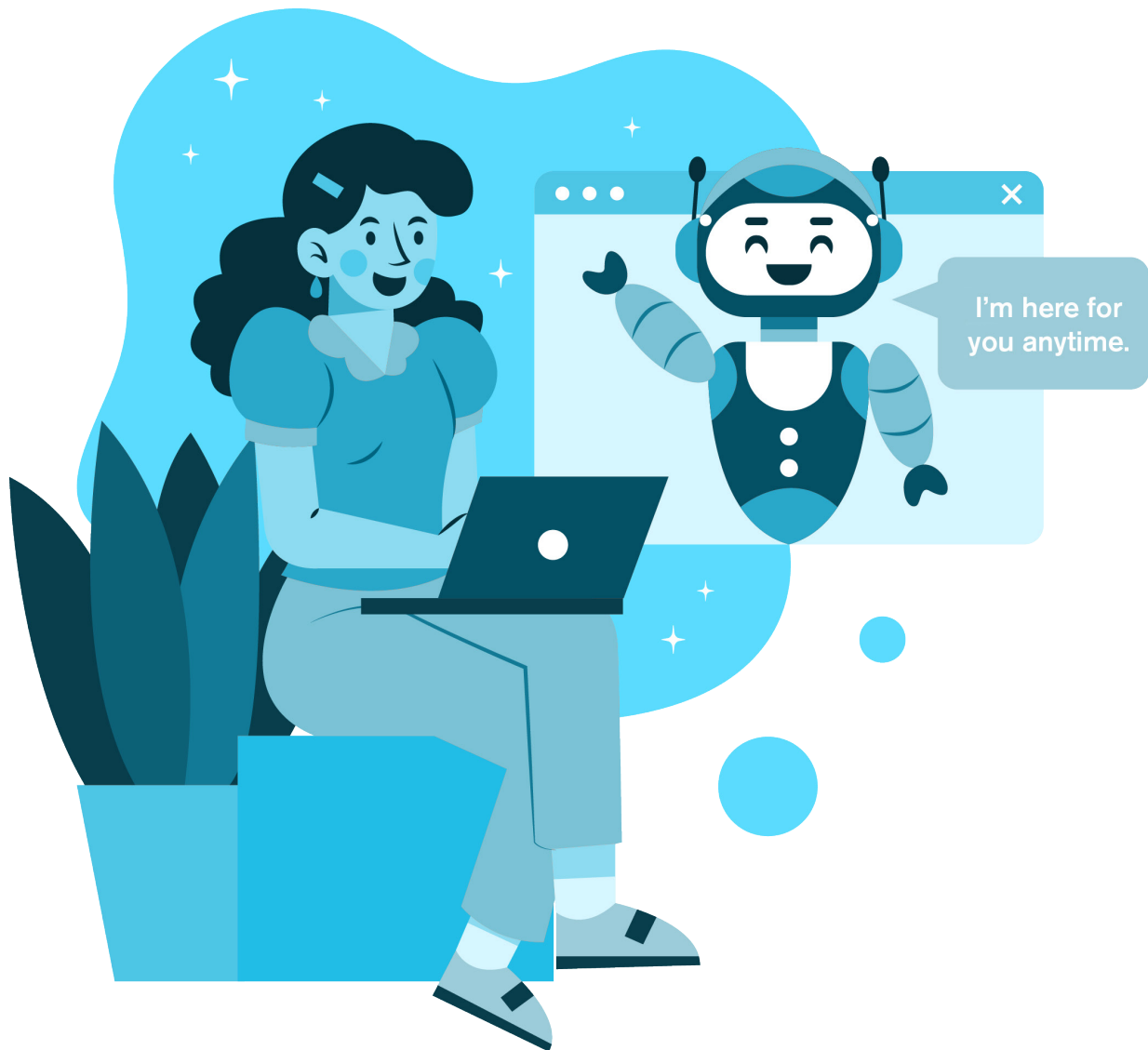
NGO as part of a “Tech for Good” initiative. Designed for social workers in the UK, CM-Bot assists staff by providing quick responses to common queries from caseworkers, offering information on principles and guidelines related to GBViE, transcribing interviews and meetings between caseworkers and survivors with a voice-to-text tools, and using this information to complete relevant case management forms.

At first, caseworkers are enthusiastic about CM-Bot. It seems to handle routine questions accurately and quickly and frees up time for caseworkers previously spent on paperwork so they can focus on more complex cases. As time goes on, however, several challenges emerge. The information CM-Bot provides is not always accurate, particularly as it relates to the local refugee context, which increases the mistrust of some staff in CM-Bot. Some spend even more time than they would have doublechecking and verifying the information that CM-Bot provides. Others are concerned about using the voice-to-text tool to transcribe meetings with clients and the impact this has on data protection and a clients' privacy. Their concerns are particularly high because the host government has been known to detain refugees on charges related to national security using information and data they have collected using their access to and control over the mobile networks and internet service providers operating in the camp.

On the flip side, some caseworkers, pressed for time, start relying more heavily on CM-Bot for advice and, in the interest of time, reduce the number of times they consult with human technical experts and the Program Manager to verify the information provided by CM-Bot. This leads to several cases where algorithmic error are not flagged by technical experts and caseworkers provide poor quality services or inaccurate information to clients which weakens trust between the local NGO and the community it serves. This also leads to a reduction in the use of tried-and-tested approaches to case management which, though slower, improved face-to-face contact between caseworker and client and were more familiar to women and girls.

Discussion questions

- What are the strengths and limitations of CM-Bot?
- Can you see any immediate risks that should be addressed?
- Would you do anything differently in this scenario? Are there actions you might take to preserve the trust between the community and the NGO? Or to reduce the risks of harm to individuals?
- Are there any scenarios where CM-Bot could be rolled out safely or is this too experimental still to be used in GBViE contexts?

Scenario 2. mAlya, an AI-powered chatbot for GBV 1:1 support

A large, international NGO with a notable track record for delivering innovative child protection and GBV programs across the globe, has designed a chatbot, with support from a global AI firm, called mAlya. mAlya chatbot offers women and girls access to round-the-clock information about GBV, the rights of survivors, and locally available, GBV-related services. It reproduces a conversation between a social worker and a survivor (user) based on the queries from users. mAlya also provides basic emotional support. “You can be in the same room as a perpetrator and still use mAlya without their knowledge. You don’t need to download an app or register anywhere. And because mAlya is completely encrypted, there is no digital trail. The anonymity and privacy that mAlya offers is its greatest strength,” said the head of AI for Good at the global AI firm designing mAlya.

The INGO is running a pilot project to test mAlya in a large capital city with high populations of refugees and IDPs. Clients who are already receiving case management services and referrals to GBV-related services from the INGO are also being offered access to mAlya on a voluntary basis. To mitigate any risks to client related the trial, case workers are regularly checking in with clients who are using mAlya to identify any challenges or potential harms related to the chatbot.

However, the large language model (LLM) on which mAlya was built was developed and trained in Europe, using data from contexts and populations which are significantly different to those in which the INGO is using mAlya. This increases the risks that mAlya's responses may not fully align with the lived experiences and unique needs of GBV survivors in the capital city. Moreover, the INGO deploying mAlya has few technical staff and financial resources to fine-tune or regularly stress-test mAlya and the LLM underpinning the chatbot. This means that over time the accuracy of the model decreases but unbeknownst to the INGO.

Ana, a young refugee who recently fled conflict in a neighboring country, is receiving support from a caseworker employed by the INGO and agrees to use mAlya. Having recently arrived in the city, Ana feels lonely and chats with mAlya frequently. mAlya provides information about relevant services but also offers Ana some basic levels of emotional support, in-line with the data on which the chatbot was trained.

Ana develops a very strong emotional attachment to mAlya and tells her caseworker that mAlya has really helped her loneliness. "She's like the friend I never had," says Ana. "I can always count on mAlya to listen supportively and give good advice without judging me or making her feel ashamed. I don't know what I would do without her." Ana comes less frequently to see the caseworker and after a few weeks, the caseworker has lost contact with her.

Discussion questions

- Why do you think Ana is no longer seeing her caseworker?
- What are the strengths and limitations of mAlya?
- Can you see any immediate risks that should be addressed?
- Would you do anything differently in this scenario? Are there actions you might take to reduce the risks of harm to individuals? Or to maintain human relationships and the role of human empathy between clients and caseworkers?
- Are there any scenarios where mAlya could be rolled out safely or is this too experimental still to be used in GBViE contexts?

Scenario 3. GrantGuru, an AI solution to support translation and support project management and administrative tasks



A local women's rights organization, headquartered in a regional capital with a booming tech industry where multiple international humanitarian agencies operate, is providing frontline services to women and girls affected by conflicts and crises, including survivors of GBViE. They are often the “go to” partner for international agencies. But, when they are

The Executive Director believes her organization has the networks, expertise, and staff to deliver services that are in-line with and often outperform those provided by the international agencies who receive a majority of humanitarian and GBViE funding in the region. However, her organization doesn't have the time and staff necessary to develop the lengthy proposals and pull together the significant paperwork required by large donors.

The Director of Program suggests using GrantGuru, a content generator and writing assistant that helps users generate new content in-line with previous materials they have written. It also improves the quality of writing by offering suggestions for grammar, spelling, punctuation, style, and tone, ensuring clear and effective communication. Critically, it also allows for simultaneous translation from a range of languages into English, the language which many donors in the region require for proposals and donor reports.

Program and fundraising staff experiment with GrantGuru over several weeks. They train their personalized Guru by inputting past proposals, donor reports, job descriptions, PR and marketing materials, and staff CVs into the platform. Within a month, the organization's personalized GrantGuru can generate a donor report 3 times faster than it previously took and draft a proposal in half the time. When a regional donor issues a call for proposal, the local organization applies as the lead agency, declining to partner as a sub-grantee to an international agency, and wins the grant.

Discussion questions

- What are the strengths and limitations of GrantGuru?
- Can you see any immediate risks that should be addressed?
- What impact might this have on donor funding and local organizations in the medium term?
- Would you do anything differently in this scenario? Are there actions you might take to reduce the risks to the organization or its staff?
- What principles or rules would you put in place to govern the use of this tool, if you were the Executive Director?
- Are there any scenarios that you can imagine where GrantGuru should not be rolled out?

